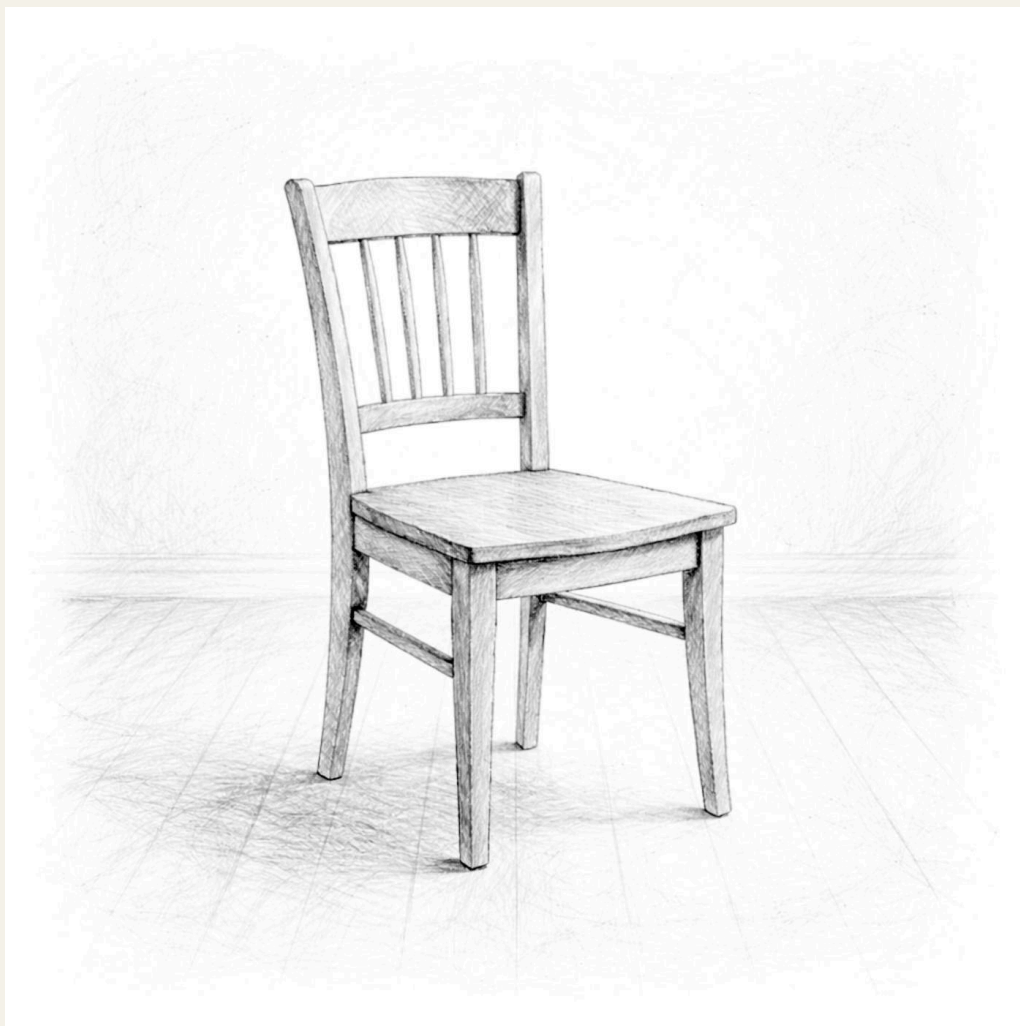


Faith



An empty wooden chair in a quiet room. It does not save anyone as furniture. It saves no one until a person sits and lets it hold them.

Before you gather

- Read Day 25, Faith, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Genesis 15:1–6 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

Where do you hate to let someone else drive, carry the load, or hold the ladder?

Leader. Control, and the fear under it. The book already asked where they rely on works and what would deepen reliance. You are only opening the question of weight. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Faith is not standing beside the chair and agreeing that chairs are strong. Faith sits down. Trust Christ alone. He came to die as our substitute. Not trying harder. Not a vague leap. He holds the weight. Your feelings do not.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Faith is trusting Jesus alone to save you and relying on Him instead of yourself.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *pistis* — faith, trust, reliance, a confidence that rests its weight on another.

MEMORY VERSE · ROMANS 5:1

Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ.

Together, open the flashcard for Faith. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Genesis 15:1–6

Abram is old and childless, and God tells him to trust a promise he cannot perform. He believed the Lord, and it was counted to him as righteousness. Romans 4 will preach this text. Stay in the story first. Faith looks where God points.

After these things the word of the LORD came to Abram in a vision: “Fear not, Abram, I am your shield; your reward shall be very great.” But Abram said, “O Lord GOD, what will you give me, for I continue childless...” And behold, the word of the LORD came to him: “This man shall not be your heir; your very own son shall be your heir.” And he brought him outside and said, “Look toward heaven, and number the stars, if you are able to number them.” Then he said to him, “So shall your offspring be.” And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What is Abram unable to produce, and what does God tell him to look at? CORE

Leader. An heir from his own body. The stars. God moves his eyes off himself and onto the promise. Faith is not a leap into the dark. It rests on what God has said.

2. Verse 6 is the line Paul loves. What, exactly, is counted to Abram as righteousness: a great deed, or believing the Lord?

Leader. Believing the Lord. Before circumcision, before Isaac, before the law. Trust in God’s word, not trying harder.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 4:4–5 uses this story: God justifies the ungodly who do not work but believe in Him who justifies the ungodly. How is sitting in the chair different from inspecting it, praising it, or holding yourself up while you touch it? CORE

Leader. Agreement is not reliance. Many church people inspect Jesus for years. Faith puts the whole weight on Him. Not a better effort. Not a vague leap.

4. Matthew 11:28–30: “Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.” Jesus offers a yoke, not a life with no Lord. How do rest and obedience fit in the same faith?

Leader. You rest from saving yourself, and you take His yoke. Faith is not laziness about holiness. It is the end of earning, and the start of following. We follow the Spirit by the Word, not by our feelings.

5. James 2:17 says faith by itself, if it does not have works, is dead. Does that cancel Romans 5:1? What is a dead “faith”, and what is a living one?

Leader. James is describing a chair nobody sits in: a claim with no trust and no fruit. Paul is describing the sitting that justifies. They are not two ways to be saved. Fruit shows the seat was taken. Do not let a debate replace that sentence.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Faith is trusting Jesus alone to save you: not trying harder, and not a vague leap.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Tell one person, in plain words, what you are trusting Christ to carry that you cannot. Ask what they are trusting. Say that faith is trust in Jesus

alone, not trying harder and not a vague leap.

Leader. Plain words, not a polished speech. The action is the telling. Christ is named. Works are not the chair. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Tell God, plainly, where you are still trying to hold yourself up.
2. Thank Him that He counts faith in Christ as righteousness.
3. Ask for a living faith that rests on Jesus and then follows Him.

Before you stumble

Someone in the room may see that they have only inspected the chair. Give them a clear way, without staging a moment: turn from self-trust and trust Christ. Jesus came to die. He was our substitute. Follow up this week. Also, Abram's faith later wobbles in Genesis 16. Counted righteousness is not flawless trust every month. Say that, so a parent of a wavering child can breathe. Do not say, "Follow your feelings into faith." Say, "Believe the gospel."

WITH STUDENTS

Have them notice the chair under them, once. If they will not put weight on it, it does them no good. Make the comparison one time, cleanly, and stop. Christ holds. They do not.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

John 6:28–29. The work of God is to believe in the One He sent. Use it when someone asks, "What do I have to do?" The answer is not to try harder. It is to trust Christ.